far greater than in India, as non-democratic rule was taking its toll, especially in East Pakistan which was more populous than West Pakistan. When general elections were finally conducted in December 1970, Mujibur Rahman's Awami League won an absolute majority, winning nearly every seat in East Pakistan. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party was dominant in West Pakistan and came in second place.[48] The transfer of power, however, dithered as the demand for provincial autonomy by the Awami League caused much consternation among political leaders in West Pakistan. After negotiations broke down in Dhaka in March 1971, Yahya Khan flew back to West Pakistan. On 26 March 1971, he launched a brutal military crackdown on the separatist movement in East Pakistan. In what is often described as 'genocide', tens, if not hundreds of thousands of civilians were killed and raped over the next eight months.[49] On 16 December 1971, the 'Liberation War' of Bangladesh finally ended with the unconditional surrender of Pakistan to the Indian army. India was dragged into the war because during those eight months, the country faced the world's largest refugee crisis ever to have been confronted by a modern sovereign state, a record unsurpassed till the present day.

In April 1971, India received about 60,000 refugees on an average on a *daily* basis.[50] In May, the daily average exceeded a 1,00,000. In June, it was a little under 70,000. Over 6 million refugees had crossed over in just three months. Nearly 4 million more refugees would arrive in the next four months, taking the peak tally to 10 million in November. Of this, West Bengal took in 7 million, while the three eastern regions of Tripura, Meghalaya and Assam received approximately one, half and a third of a million respectively. In some districts, the influx exceeded the district's pre-influx population. Of the 10 million, nearly 7 million lived in refugee camps and the others lived on their own, on the streets or with friends and relatives. This was an extraordinary refugee crisis that required an extraordinary response, involving not only the government but other organizations, not only Indian but from the wider global community.

The Indian government pursued an open-door policy on the influx of refugees on humanitarian grounds. Refugees were first registered at border